

Psychological safety during change

Practical tools for leaders and teams after DDD Perth

When you cannot offer certainty, people still need a reliable way to understand what is happening, raise concerns and influence what comes next. This guide gives you short activities and conversation scripts you can use at work.

Start with one conversation

At your next team meeting, ask: “What are we seeing that the change plan may have missed?” Give people time to think, hear each response, then say what you will do with what you heard.

The four conditions to strengthen

Condition	What it sounds like
Clarity	“Here is what we know, what is still unknown and when I will update you.”
Voice	“What is harder in practice than it looks on the plan?”
Choice	“This decision is fixed. Which parts of implementation can you shape?”
Connection	“I do not have a new answer today. How is this affecting the work?”

The aim is to make speaking up useful. A question without a response can make silence more likely next time.



1 Create a Third Space

The TIPT Third Space Framework™ describes five conditions for conversations that help people make sense of difficult change together.

Equal voice

Use a round or a written prompt so each person has a chance to contribute. Do not rely on whoever speaks first.

Psychological distance

Put a scenario, diagram or LEGO® model between people and the issue. Invite discussion about the model before asking for personal experience.

Shared storytelling

Ask people what their contribution means to them. Let the speaker define it.

Shared mental models

Compare what different people are noticing. Name where views agree and where important differences remain.

Collective reflection

Ask what the group learned and what practical response should follow. Assign an owner and a time to report back.

A 12-minute team activity

Time	Facilitator prompt
2 min	“Build or sketch what this change feels like when it is hard to speak up.” Everyone makes a model or sketch; a fictional scenario is fine.
4 min	Invite each person to explain one part of their model or sketch, sharing only what they feel comfortable sharing. Others listen and ask only clarifying questions.
3 min	“What patterns or differences do we notice?” Record both shared themes and exceptions.
3 min	“Add one thing that would make this safer. What can we try in the next two weeks?” Name an owner.

Explain why everyone participating matters: each perspective helps the team see more of the picture. Everyone builds or sketches, while each person chooses how much to share. Do not ask for trauma disclosures or turn a team discussion into therapy. Follow your workplace’s support and escalation processes if a safety issue emerges.

2 Lead when answers are incomplete

Use this update structure whenever a decision, timeline or system is still taking shape.

Step	Say or do
What is known	State the confirmed decision or fact in plain language.
What is unknown	Name the question you cannot yet answer. Avoid guessing.
What happens next	Give a date or event for the next update, and keep it even if there is no new decision.
What you need to hear	Ask what risks, workload effects or customer impacts people can see.
How you will respond	Record concerns, explain who will review them, and close the loop.

A script you can adapt

“The decision to introduce the new tool has been made. The rollout sequence is still being worked out. We will give you an update next Thursday, even if some questions remain open. What might this change make harder for customers or for your day-to-day work? We will record those concerns and come back with what we can change.”

When somebody challenges the plan

Thank them for identifying a possible issue. Ask what they have observed, who it affects and what might help. Separate the fixed decision from the parts that can still change. Tell the team how the concern will be assessed.

A useful response after a concern

“Here is what we heard. Here is what we changed. Here is what we could not change, and why. Here is what we will watch next.”

3 Apply it to an AI rollout

A new AI tool is announced as a way to improve speed. Some employees may privately wonder whether their roles or skills are at risk. A quiet announcement meeting cannot tell you whether those concerns have been resolved. Silence can look like alignment.

Run a 15-minute implementation huddle

Minute	Ask	Capture
0-3	"What do we know about the tool and what remains uncertain?"	Confirmed facts and open questions
3-7	"Where could the new workflow fail for staff or customers?"	Risks and affected roles
7-11	"Which parts of the rollout can we test or adjust?"	Options and owners
11-15	"What support would help you raise a problem early?"	Support and update date

After the huddle

Publish the questions and their owners. Give an update at the agreed time. Track whether people raise issues early enough to improve the rollout, and whether they hear back after doing so.

What to observe

- Are questions coming from different roles, or only from a few confident people?
- Are concerns raised in the meeting or only afterwards?
- Can people identify a change made because someone spoke up?

4 Try a 30-day experiment

Choose one team or project. Keep the experiment small enough that you can act on the feedback.

Week	Action
1	Ask what feels uncertain. Name the next update point and invite risks from every role.
2	Run the 12-minute Third Space activity. Choose one change the team can test.
3	Check whether the change made it easier to ask, challenge or flag a problem.
4	Share what you heard, what changed, what remains unresolved and what happens next.

Measure what changed

- Count questions and concerns raised before and after the activity, including those offered privately.
- Ask a short anonymous question: “I can raise a concern about this change and expect a useful response.”
- Log what leaders did with concerns and how quickly the team heard back.
- Record one concrete decision or implementation detail that improved because someone spoke up.

Leader self-check

Am I visible? Have I said what I know and what I do not? Whose perspective have I not heard? What will I report back, and when?

Bring TIPT into your workplace

Tanya Hallett and TIPT help leaders and teams build psychological safety during change through practical workshops, LEGO® Serious Play® facilitation and trauma-informed advisory support. We can tailor a Third Space session, leadership program or change conversation to your organisation.

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